

Speculative Proposal — Template + Guide

Speculative Proposal — Template + Guide

ASN 1 Component — Due: beginning of Week 5

See full assignment brief: ASN 1: Potluck + Speculative Proposal

What This Is

A proposal in this experimental media arts lab is not meant to be seen as a list of promised deliverables. It is more so a **construction of conditions**. You are aiming to act with precision (pragmatism) to catalyze the unknown (speculative).

- Manning and Massumi call this *speculative pragmatism*: the work of building a situation that allows something not yet known to happen.

This document is a living artifact. It will be revised (due at Week 10). The gap between the two versions (what changed and why) is itself part of the research/processes.

Format

A PDF to Blackboard. Prose, annotated diagrams, hybrid, etc.

If you wish to depart significantly from this structure, talk to me first.

The Five Components

1. Your Driving Curiosity — Finding Your "Dog"

What is the specific, situated thing that's pulling you? A *relation*. A question that has *you* in it.

- Loveless, following Haraway, calls this your "dog," the particular thing you can't stop following, the pull that refuses to generalize away.

Focus not on *what* you're making but on *whom and what you are touching* when you engage this process.

Be specific. *"I'm interested in how capacitive touch changes when the conductive surface is hair, not metal; what shifts about agency, contact, and consent"* is a driving curiosity. *"I'm interested in interactivity and the body"* is not.

- Try writing: *"I am obsessively inquiring into the gap between **and** because... What I don't understand yet is..."*
-

2. The Matter-Network (Your Assemblage)

A map — visual or written — of the tools, materials, environments, bodies, and relations that constitute your project's technical and social apparatus. Not a list, A map. One that shows how things depend on, condition, or transform each other.

Pull from your Tool Audit findings here. Locate the specific "theoretical instruments" (the audio buffers, touch thresholds, protocol choices) you're choosing to keep in your loop and why.

Include:

- Hardware and software tools
- Physical materials, objects, surfaces, spaces
- Bodies (whose? doing what?)
- Data (what kind, how captured, how stored)
- Site or environment
- Protocols and signal flows
- Dependencies — what does X require Y for?
- Unknowns — things you still need to figure out

A rough sketch is fine. The point is to see the whole apparatus.

3. Enabling Constraints

Define **3–5 specific, formal rules** that will govern your making process.

- Remember: a constraint is not a limitation; it is a catalyst for surprise.
 - They are conditions that creates productive friction without pre-terminating the outcome.

Constraints should be typed (as in categorized). Aim for at least one of each:

- **Technical constraint** — governs your signal chain or tools (e.g., *"No audio playback over 1.5 seconds."*)

- **Material constraint** — governs physical or environmental conditions (e.g., *"Must be triggered by physical proximity only — no keyboard/mouse input."*)
- **Affective constraint** — governs relationship, attention, or intent (e.g., *"Incorporate one error from the console as an intentional feature rather than a bug to fix."*)

For each constraint, write:

- **The constraint:** what it is, exactly
- **Why this one:** what pressure or generativity you expect from it
- **What it forecloses:** what you're giving up (a constraint that forecloses nothing isn't a constraint)

Ask yourself: are your constraints based on your skills, or are they hiding your skills? Both are valid starting points, but know which one you're doing.

4. Epistemic Positioning Statement

A paragraph (or two) on the epistemics of your project. This is where Magnusson, Agre, and Barad land in your actual work.

Try: *"This tool wants me to produce ____; I will use constraint X to force it toward [a different outcome]."*

Address at least two of the following:

- What does your primary tool know — what worldview does it embed — and how is that in tension or alignment with what you're trying to make?
- Whose body, whose context, whose way of knowing is your apparatus built for? Is that yours?
- Where do you anticipate hitting the tool's wall — the limit of what it can think?
- How are you entangled with your tools and materials? Where is the boundary between you, the tool, and the work genuinely unclear?

5. The Boundary Object

Loveless speaks of the *"boundary object."* This is a result that lives between institutional expectation and personal research identity. Both matter, and they don't always want the same thing.

Be honest about the tension:

- **What does the department/course need to see?** What counts as evidence of rigor, craft, or completion in this context?

- **What does your practice / research identity need?** What would it mean for this work to be true to what's actually pulling you?

These don't have to be the same thing. But naming the gap between them is useful; it helps you navigate toward something that satisfies both without collapsing into either.

Notes

On uncertainty: the proposal should contain some. If you're not uncertain about anything, you're not actually speculating, you're describing a predetermined outcome. Uncertainty is evidence the inquiry is live.

On revision: this document will be different at Week 10. Document your reasoning now so you can see the transformation. The gap between versions is part of the work.

On format departures: if prose feels wrong for how you think, talk to me. Diagrams, annotated images, recorded audio, the format should not determine the rigor.

See also: Research-Creation thread · Enabling Constraints thread · Epistemic Tools thread